DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 7

n8n expert

Profession 7 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

An n8n expert builds advanced workflows in n8n: nodes, expressions, error handling, sub-workflows, AI nodes and self-hosting. n8n is popular with developers and operations teams because workflows can include custom code and run on the company's own server.

What professionals do every day

Designs workflows, writes expressions and small code steps, handles errors and retries, connects databases and APIs, sets up credentials safely, self-hosts when required and monitors executions.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Companies with many systems need reliable, customisable automation. An n8n expert delivers it with control over data and cost.

- Complex processes that simple tools cannot handle.
- Data that must stay on the company's own server.
- Failed workflows that nobody notices.

Skills you need

- n8n nodes, triggers, connections and expressions.
- JSON and webhooks (Development and IT, Part 1).
- Error workflows and monitoring.
- Credentials and secret handling.
- Self-hosting with Docker (official n8n guide).

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
n8n	Workflow automation with code steps	Community self-hosted	Cloud plans	n8n.io
n8n documentation	Official reference	Free	Free	docs.n8n.io
n8n learning portal	Official courses	Free	Free	learn.n8n.io
Docker	Run n8n in a container	Free	Free	www.docker.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish

Beginner	A workflow with a trigger, two nodes and a condition.
Intermediate	A workflow with an error handler and an alert.
Advanced	A sub-workflow reused by three parent flows, with monitoring.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Lead capture with CRM and email follow-up.
- **Intermediate:** Customer support triage with AI classification.
- **Advanced:** Weekly business report from three data sources.

Client-ready portfolio project

A complete n8n system for a fictional business: lead capture, AI triage, CRM update, error alerting and a monitoring page. See the n8n complete guide in the AI tools series for the Gmail version.

Worked example

Worked example. A webhook receives a lead. A condition routes hot leads to a call task and others to a nurture email. An error workflow sends an alert whenever any run fails.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Error handling for a production workflow

Business problem: A workflow sends customer emails. If the email service fails, the team must know, and the lead must not be lost.

Steps

1. Add a Set node to keep only the fields you need.
2. Save each lead to a sheet before sending any email.
3. Add an error workflow that sends a staff alert with the execution link.
4. Break the email credential on purpose and confirm the alert arrives.
5. Restore the credential and confirm the lead is still saved and the email sends once.

Expected output: A failing test that triggers an alert, and proof that no lead was lost.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Saving first and sending second means a failed email never loses a lead. The error workflow converts silent failures into alerts. Deliberately breaking a credential in a test is the only reliable way to prove the alert works.

Common mistakes

- Storing secrets in expressions instead of credentials.
- No error workflow, so failures go unnoticed.

- Running a self-hosted instance without updates and backups.
- Large loops without limits, which can exhaust API quotas.

Freelancing opportunities

- n8n builds and maintenance for growing businesses.
- Self-hosting set-up for companies that need data control.
- Freelance briefs for 'n8n', 'workflow automation', 'API integration'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- n8n documentation
- n8n learning portal

Part of **Master Freelancing: AI and Automation**. Back to the chapter list on skillnavora.in · Open the full textbook. Official links in this chapter were not checked live; confirm before relying on them.